one of the most dangerous jobs in the world. At a time when American democracy was improving its many self-correcting mechanisms, Soviet totalitarianism was refining its triple self-surveilling and self-terrorising apparatus.

TOTAL CONTROL

Totalitarian regimes are based on controlling the flow of information and are suspicious of any independent channels of information. When military officers, state officials or ordinary citizens exchange information, they can build trust. If they come to trust one another, they can organise resistance to the regime. Therefore, a key tenet of totalitarian regimes is that wherever people meet and exchange information, the regime should be there too, to keep an eye on them. In the 1930s, this was one principle that Hitler and Stalin shared.

On 31 March 1933, two months after Hitler became chancellor, the Nazis passed the Coordination Act (Gleichschaltungsgesetz). This stipulated that by 30 April 1933, all political, social and cultural organisations throughout Germany – from municipalities to football clubs and local choirs – must be run according to Nazi ideology, as organs of the Nazi state. It upended life in every city and hamlet in Germany.

For example, in the small Alpine village of Oberstdorf, the democratically elected municipal council met for the last time on 21 April 1933, and three days later it was replaced by an unelected Nazi council that appointed a Nazi mayor. Since the Nazis alone allegedly knew what the people *really* wanted, who other than Nazis could implement the people's will? Oberstdorf also had about fifty associations and clubs, ranging from a beekeeping society to an alpinist club. They all had to conform to the Coordination Act, adjusting their boards, membership and statutes to Nazi demands, hoisting the swastika flag and concluding every meeting with the 'Horst Wessel Song', the Nazi Party's anthem. On 6 April 1933, the Oberstdorf fishing society banned Jews from its ranks. None of the thirty-two members was Jewish, but they felt they had to prove their Aryan credentials to the new regime.[81]

Things were even more extreme in Stalin's USSR. Whereas the Nazis still allowed church organisations and private businesses some partial